



STATUS QUO: Karunanidhi says he will not insist on PMK's ouster from UPA

among others. Recently, S. Ramadoss upped the ante by remarking that the DMK Government was "unfit to rule" and in a mock examination, ruled Karunanidhi "a failure". DMK sources say such taunts happened despite Karunanidhi giving in to requests and even demands made by the PMK.

Till a few months ago, it was widely believed that despite the friction, the alliance would continue well into the next elections. But Karunanidhi's hackles were raised after PMK President G.K. Mani recently went to Ooty to meet AIADMK General Secretary J. Jayalalitha who was holidaying in her Kodanadu estate. Though Jayalalitha refused to meet Mani, she sent out signals that she would not be averse to meeting S. Ramadoss on her return to Chennai later this month. The two leaders will have a chance to meet at the wedding of the son of a top PMK functionary with an AIADMK leader's daughter. A few months ago, Jayalalitha had said that her party's doors were open for alliances. When asked if the AIADMK

would accept PMK if it quits the DPA, she said, "We will welcome them with great respect."

The PMK's ouster signals a shift of sands in the state's politics, which could well be a throwback to a decade ago. A possible line-up of the AIADMK-BJP-MDMK-PMK would then take on the DMK-Congress-communist combine in the next Lok Sabha polls. But for that to happen, the PMK will have to first quit the UPA, which seems unlikely at the moment.

Sources say that the DMK has eased the PMK out of the alliance only to avoid actor Vijayakanth's DMDK joining the AIADMK alliance. Vijayakanth's party, which has been splitting the AIADMK vote bank in the last assembly elections, civic polls and the assembly by-elections in Madurai, is seen as a small but sure threat to both the DMK and the AIADMK. Karunanidhi's calculation was that if the

PMK, Vijayakanth's arch rival, goes to the AIADMK, the actor-turned-politician has either to come to the DMK front or contest the elections alone. However, Vijayakanth is very clear that his party would go it alone in the elections. "I will be next chief minister of the state," he keeps repeating at his public meetings. With these alliance equations changing, the party left in the lurch is the Congress. It is an alliance partner in the state, but does not share power as the DMK has not given any ministerial berths to Congress MLAs.

S. Ramadoss has a lot to mull over. Back at her holiday home, Jayalalitha

wears an ear-to-ear grin. But no one is perhaps happier than Karunanidhi who no more has to deal with a foe in friend's disguise. He has the added satisfaction that his other major partners, the communists and the Congress, will see him through a full term. ■

Karunanidhi has the Congress and the communists at his side who will see him through a full term.